

— the checklist

The **47-point** cold email deliverability checklist.

Every check we run before, during, and after a campaign — in the order we run them. Built from 10,000+ mailboxes on SendKit infrastructure.

47

CHECKS

5

PHASES

10k+

MAILBOXES STUDIED

60 min

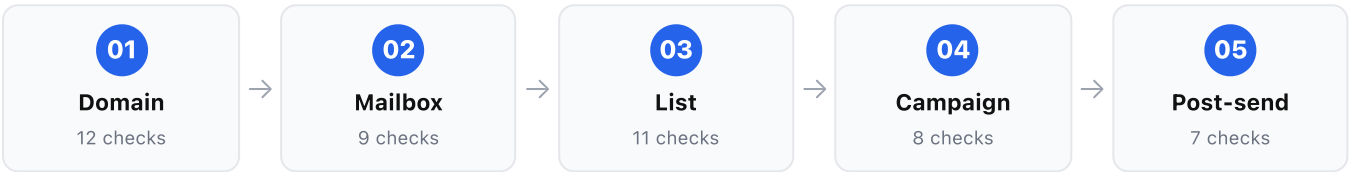
FIRST AUDIT

— why it matters

Deliverability is a weekly habit, not a one-time setup

Most teams check deliverability AFTER a campaign underperforms. By then, you’re recovering reputation, not preventing damage. This checklist reverses the order — 47 checks run before a single email goes out.

The checks are grouped into 5 phases. Phase 1 (domain) precedes Phase 2 (mailbox) precedes Phase 3 (list), and so on. Skip a phase and the next one inherits the debt. Run them in order.



Contents

01	Domain foundation DNS, subdomain strategy, SPF/DKIM/DMARC. If this is wrong, nothing downstream can save you.	12 CHECKS
02	Mailbox setup Warmup, signatures, sending limits, IP assignment. Where first-send reputation is built.	9 CHECKS
03	List hygiene The bounce-rate killer most teams skip. Most cold email fails here, not at copy.	11 CHECKS
04	Campaign day Subject, body, volume, timing, tracking pixels. What the recipient actually sees.	8 CHECKS
05	Post-send Bounce rate, complaint rate, blacklist status. Your early-warning system.	7 CHECKS

• PHASE 01 · 12 CHECKS

Domain foundation

DNS, subdomain strategy, authentication. If this is wrong, nothing downstream can save you.

DNS & authentication

7 OF 12

- ☐ Primary domain is **NOT** the sending domain. Use `mail.yourdomain.com` or a lookalike.
Burning the primary domain kills your corporate email too. Always isolate.
- ☐ Sending domain age is 30+ days before first cold send.
Fresh domains get spam-sandboxed automatically.
- ☐ MX records pointed at your email host, not a parked domain.
Receivers check MX + A records together. Missing MX = red flag.
- ☐ SPF record published, under the 10 DNS-lookup limit. ⚡ automated by SendKit
Over 10 lookups = silent permerror at Gmail.
- ☐ DKIM with 2048-bit key (not 1024). ⚡ automated by SendKit
Gmail deprecated 1024-bit DKIM in 2024.
- ☐ DMARC published starting at `p=none`. ⚡ automated by SendKit
Required for 5k+/day senders under Gmail & Yahoo's Feb 2024 rules.
- ☐ Reverse DNS (PTR) set on sending IP. ⚡ automated by SendKit
Measurable sender-score drop without matching PTR.

Reputation & compliance

5 OF 12

- ☐ Custom tracking domain with valid SSL. ⚡ automated by SendKit
Shared tracking domains (bit.ly, default ESP subdomains) are frequently on URIBL.
- ☐ Domain not on Spamhaus / SURBL / URIBL. ⚡ monitored by SendKit
Check before sending, not after bounces spike.
- ☐ WHOIS privacy disabled.
Many ESPs deprioritize privacy-protected domains, especially under 90 days.
- ☐ A real website exists at the root domain.
Empty root = instant spam flag at Outlook.
- ☐ Unsubscribe link resolves; one-click unsub live. ⚡ automated by SendKit
Non-compliant senders lose placement at 5k+/day (Gmail/Yahoo 2024 rules).

• HOW SENDKIT HANDLES THIS PHASE

SPF, DKIM, DMARC auto-publish on every connected mailbox. DNS drift checked every 4 hours. Dedicated IPs (with PTR) ship on every plan. Custom tracking domains provision in one click with auto-rotating SSL.

• PHASE 02 · 9 CHECKS

Mailbox setup

Where first-send reputation is built. A mailbox sending cold on day 1 looks exactly like a spammer to Gmail's filters.

Warmup & behavior

4 OF 9

- ☐ Warmup has been running 14+ days before sending cold. ⚡ [AI warmup by SendKit](#)
Under 14 days, reputation lacks an engagement baseline.
- ☐ Warmup sends spread across real-human hours, not 24/7. ⚡ [AI warmup by SendKit](#)
A mailbox sending at 03:12 looks like a bot.
- ☐ Mailbox signature includes name, role, unsubscribe link.
Empty signatures correlate with higher spam placement at Outlook.
- ☐ Display name matches the sender's real LinkedIn identity.
Gmail cross-references display names against its identity graph.

Limits & isolation

5 OF 9

- ☐ Reply-to address is monitored. 404 replies kill sender score. ⚡ [unified inbox on SendKit](#)
Gmail factors reply deliverability into sender scoring.
- ☐ Per-mailbox daily limit: ≤30 on new, ≤100 on mature. ⚡ [automated by SendKit](#)
Volume curves exceeding this consistently trigger rate-shaping.
- ☐ Mailbox rotation: ≤30 leads per mailbox per day per campaign. ⚡ [automated by SendKit](#)
Higher concentration reads as list-blast.
- ☐ Dedicated IP assigned, or at minimum an isolated pool. ⚡ [default on SendKit](#)
Shared IP reputation drops when pool-mates send spam.
- ☐ Mailbox-to-IP mapping is sticky, not rotating. ⚡ [sticky mapping on SendKit](#)
Rotating IPs prevents reputation from compounding for that mailbox.

- **SendKit includes dedicated IPs on every plan.**

Most platforms lock dedicated IPs behind enterprise tier. On SendKit, every mailbox gets hash-based sticky-assigned to a specific IP. The IP is yours, and stays yours.

• PHASE 03 · 11 CHECKS

List hygiene

The category most teams skip — and the one most frequently responsible for a 4%+ bounce rate that kills a campaign on day 1.

Validation & suppression

6 OF 11

- ☐ Email verification run within the last 30 days. ⚡ [built-in verifier on SendKit](#)
Inbox status changes constantly. Stale verification = invalid.
- ☐ Catch-all domains removed or manually verified. ⚡ [catch-all detection on SendKit](#)
Catch-all = no bounce signal. Sending to invalid with no bounce is worse than bouncing.
- ☐ Role-based addresses excluded: info@, sales@, contact@. ⚡ [auto-filtered on SendKit](#)
High complaint rates; often forwarded to groups.
- ☐ Bounce list from past 90 days suppressed. ⚡ [auto-suppressed on SendKit](#)
Hitting the same bounced address twice compounds reputation damage.
- ☐ Unsubscribe list suppressed **across all campaigns**. ⚡ [cross-campaign on SendKit](#)
A single cross-campaign send to an unsub is a complaint trigger.
- ☐ Known spam traps removed. Use a provider with trap detection.
One trap hit can land you on Spamhaus for months.

Enrichment & routing

5 OF 11

- ☐ List enriched with LinkedIn/title data. ⚡ [built-in lead finder on SendKit](#)
Bad data produces bad targeting, which produces complaints.
- ☐ Duplicates removed. ⚡ [auto-dedupe on SendKit](#)
Duplicate hits = same complaint twice.
- ☐ Geographic timezone distribution mapped. ⚡ [auto-detected on SendKit](#)
Send timing can't be optimized without recipient location.
- ☐ ESP distribution mapped. Plan ESP matching. ⚡ [ESP matching on SendKit](#)
Gmail-to-Gmail has higher placement than cross-ESP.
- ☐ Contact acquisition source documented for compliance.
GDPR/CAN-SPAM defense if complaint rate spikes.

• HOW SENDKIT HANDLES THIS PHASE

Email validation runs at import time. Catch-alls get flagged. Role-based addresses filter out automatically. Bounces and unsubscribes suppress across every campaign on your account, not just the one that triggered them.

● PHASE 04 · 8 CHECKS

Campaign day

What the recipient actually sees — and what Gmail's spam filter evaluates in the first 50ms.

Message structure

5 OF 8

- ☐ First-step subject line under 60 chars, no spam triggers. ⚡ [subject-line tester on SendKit](#)
"FREE", "GUARANTEE", ALL CAPS = automatic placement penalty.
- ☐ First-step body under 125 words.
Longer first-touch emails correlate with lower placement.
- ☐ No tracking pixels on step 1. ⚡ [per-step toggle on SendKit](#)
Gmail's promotions classifier weighs pixels heavily.
- ☐ Links: max 1 per email, always to your root domain.
Multiple outbound links look like a newsletter.
- ☐ No image-only emails, no attachments on step 1.
Image-only = strongest spam signal Gmail uses.

Send mechanics

3 OF 8

- ☐ Send window: 09:00–11:00 recipient-local time. ⚡ [timezone-aware on SendKit](#)
Inbox placement tests show higher primary-folder rates in morning windows.
- ☐ Ramp: ≤20 new mailboxes/day onto a fresh sequence. ⚡ [ramp scheduler on SendKit](#)
More than 20 going hot at once reads as synchronized spam.
- ☐ Pre-send inbox placement test on 5% of the list. ⚡ [built-in placement tester on SendKit](#)
Catch spam placement before burning the full list.

- **The pre-send seed test is the highest-ROI 5 minutes on this page.**

If step 1 lands in promotions or spam on a 10-seed test, fixing it costs nothing. Finding out after a 5,000-send burn costs the mailbox.

• PHASE 05 · 7 CHECKS

Post-send

Your early-warning system. Most deliverability failures are preventable if caught within 48 hours.

Reputation signals

4 OF 7

- ☐ Bounce rate under 2%. Kill the campaign if it goes over. ⚡ [auto-kill by SendKit](#)
Above 4% and Gmail de-prioritizes the sending domain for weeks.
- ☐ Spam complaint rate under 0.1%. ⚡ [auto-kill by SendKit](#)
Gmail's threshold for auto-spam routing is ~0.3%. Stay below.
- ☐ Reply rate tracked separately from open rate. ⚡ [reply-rate dashboard on SendKit](#)
Opens are unreliable post iOS 15. Replies are the real signal.
- ☐ Blacklist check within 24 hours of send. ⚡ [24/7 monitoring on SendKit](#)
Spamhaus listings can happen from a single bad batch.

The 10-second diagnostic

IF OPENS DROP

Check blacklist status first.

IF REPLIES DROP

Check inbox placement
(seed test).

IF BOUNCES SPIKE

Check list age & verification.

Cadence & recovery

3 OF 7

- ☐ Inbox placement re-check on day 3. ⚡ [scheduled on SendKit](#)
Day-3 drops are the earliest indicator of reputation damage.
- ☐ Unsubscribes processed within 24 hours. ⚡ [auto-processed on SendKit](#)
Gmail 2024 requirement.
- ☐ Next campaign delayed 48h if anything above failed. ⚡ [enforced by auto mailbox protection](#)
Running a second campaign on a wounded mailbox compounds damage.

reference

Every number that matters, on one page

Bookmark this. These are the thresholds we use internally to decide whether a campaign ships, warns, or gets killed.

METRIC	HEALTHY	WARNING	KILL
Bounce rate	< 2%	2–4%	> 4%
Spam complaint rate	< 0.1%	0.1–0.3%	> 0.3%
Reply rate (B2B)	> 4%	1–4%	< 1%
Per-mailbox daily (new)	≤ 30	31–50	> 50
Per-mailbox daily (mature)	≤ 100	101–150	> 150
Domain age for cold sends	≥ 30 days	14–30 days	< 14 days
Warmup before first cold send	≥ 14 days	7–14 days	< 7 days
Leads/mailbox/day/campaign	≤ 30	31–50	> 50
New mailboxes ramping/day	≤ 20	21–50	> 50
Pre-send seed test list size	≥ 5% of send	1–5%	< 1%

Manually or with SendKit

PHASE	MANUAL OPTION	SENDKIT
Domain	mxttoolbox + manual DNS editor; weekly blacklist checks	 auto SPF/DKIM/DMARC + continuous DNS validation + 24/7 blacklist monitoring
Mailbox	Manual warmup tool + spreadsheet-tracked ramp	 auto AI warmup + ramp scheduling + dedicated IPs on every plan
List	Third-party verifier + manual suppression lists	 auto Built-in validation + catch-all detection + cross-campaign suppression
Campaign	Google Postmaster + external seed-test service	 auto Built-in inbox placement tester + ESP matching + per-step pixel toggle
Post-send	Manual bounce monitoring + manual blacklist rechecks	 auto Auto mailbox protection + continuous placement monitoring + auto-unsubs

Every SendKit plan includes the full stack. No add-ons.

— takeaways

Five takeaways for teams that skim

If you only read one page, read this one. The five ideas behind the 47 checks.

01

Deliverability is 47 controllable variables. If inbox placement drops, one of them is wrong. Run the checklist.

02

Run it in phase order. Domain → mailbox → list → campaign → post-send. Phase debt compounds downstream.

03

The pre-send seed test is the highest-ROI five minutes on this page. Always run it on 5% before the full send.

04

Opens are unreliable post-iOS 15. Use reply rate as the real signal. Track it separately from opens.

05

If you'd rather not run all 47 manually every week, SendKit automates 38 of them — dedicated IPs on every plan, AI warmup, inbox placement testing, auto mailbox protection, continuous blacklist monitoring. No add-ons.

Run this checklist every Monday. Ship cold email every day.

SendKit automates most of it. Dedicated IPs on every plan. AI warmup that passes ESP detection. Auto mailbox protection that pauses before damage spreads. One subscription, no add-ons.

[Start sending with SendKit](#)[See dedicated IPs →](#)

Set up in under 15 minutes · 14-day free trial · No credit card required

Built from 10,000+ mailboxes. Engineered for primary inbox.

SendKit is a cold email infrastructure platform. Dedicated IPs on every plan. Isolated sending infrastructure. AI warmup that passes ESP detection. Inbox placement testing. Auto mailbox protection. Blacklist monitoring. Email validation. All included. No add-ons.

sendkit.ai · hello@sendkit.ai

This checklist is drawn from SendKit's platform data across 10,000+ mailboxes. The thresholds reflect observed performance patterns. For the full stack — warmup, inbox placement testing, blacklist monitoring, auto mailbox protection — start a trial at sendkit.ai.